

IS THE CONNECTED WORLD A Bane or A Boon?



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Intelligent devices and their ever-growing networks encompassing our daily lives have emerged as the utopian idea for our tech-savvy generation. As predicted by research firm IDC, by 2020 there will be more than 28 billion objects with data-exchange capabilities.

The Internet of Things (IoT) is already on its way to materialise as the next big tech trend. Its enormous growth rate can be estimated from a report by Gartner Inc., which indicates that the use of IoT devices in 2015 was up by 30 per cent from 2014 with over 4.9 billion connected devices. Further, according to IDC, the IoT market is expected to hit US\$ 7.1 trillion by 2020.

The security threat

The IoT is central to smart homes, smart shopping, smart transportation and smart healthcare. Embedded software, hardware devices and communication services are getting interconnected, forming a complicated network of information, most of which is stored in the Internet. With increased proliferation of Internet networks, security has emerged as the most critical factor in its existent infrastructure, as devices are vulnerable to sophisticated hacking activities.

In fact, the perilous security condition has facilitated the protrusion of a massive IoT security market side by side. According to a forecast by Technavio, the global IoT security market will grow at a compound annual rate of 54.93 per cent over the period 2014 to 2019. Hence, the IoT is offering the business world increasing security risks besides opportunities.

With billions of connected devices, security attacks and data thefts will emerge as a daunting challenge for the industry. Our sensitive personal information will become vulnerable in cloud domain.

The IoT has decentralised entry points for malware, exposing a smart network to potential security threats. As loads of devices are interconnected in a smart system, a minute security glitch in a device may create a loophole for the entire network, exposing every bit of information within it.

A report by Cisco on cyber security threads has identified a number of aspects related to IoT security. It reveals that IoT devices could be used as infection vectors to spread malware across organisations.

Infection could lead to denial-of-service attacks, causing serious damage to life and property. As IoT devices are increasingly used in extremely sensitive